

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 11 OF 12

Open Hands

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For open hands: for everything you have held, and everything you are ready to give back.



Father Lucas



BOOK 11

This book: Surrender, trust, growing old, fear of tomorrow, and thanks.

How it goes: We start with empty hands and the real cost of holding on. Then we look at tomorrow, the body, and the years, and we hand them over one at a time. Then we put the house in order and say what needs saying. We end in praise, in the company of the saints, and with a candle.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

BOOK II

The Year of Untied Knots · Book 11 of 12 · Days 306–336

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

Good morning, my friend.

You have come a long way with Mary. Now we do the quietest work of the year. We open our hands.

I don't mean the knots are gone. Some of them are still on the table. I mean that a hand clenched around everything can't be held by anyone. This month we look at what we can't control: tomorrow, the body, time, the empty places. And we look at what we can give: thanks, praise, the whole day.

I'll be here each morning. Remember what we learned in the first book. A loosened knot can tie again. Hands that open every morning give it nothing to hold.

Father Lucas

THE MONTH IN FOUR WEEKS

Days 1–7: Open your hands, and see what control has cost. Say Mary's yes. Trust only the next hour.

Days 8–14: Growing old is a calling. Let others carry something, give away what you hoard, and be still.

Days 15–21: Sing a little. Face the fear of dying gently, put the house in order, and say what needs saying.

Days 22–31: Hold the rosary, find small joys, praise without reason, and keep company with the saints. End with the candle.

THREE PROMISES FOR THIS MONTH

I. *I will let someone carry one small thing for me.*

II. *I will thank God for something ordinary every day.*

III. *I will keep tomorrow outside until I've had breakfast.*

IV. --

MY NAME



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WEEK 1

Week 1

DAYS 306 TO 312

This week: Open Hands; What Control Cost You; Not My Will; Yes, Like Mary.



DAY 306

Open Hands

The eyes of all wait for you. You give them their food in due season. You open your hand, and satisfy the desire of every living thing.

PSALM 145:15-16 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Look at your hands before you reach for anything. For one minute they're empty. That's the whole lesson of this month, and it takes thirty-one mornings to learn.

For eleven books you've been naming knots and handing them over. Some of you handed them over and took them back by lunch. So did I. Here's what I've noticed. A fist can't hold a cup, or another hand, or a rosary. An open hand can hold all three, one at a time.

So we start with nothing in them. Nothing at all.

Lord Jesus, here are my hands. Look at them. They have washed a thousand dishes, signed a thousand papers, and held people I love. They're tired of gripping. For one minute I won't hold anything. Not the worry, not the plan, not the phone. Put into them only what you want me to carry today. Mary, sit beside me while they rest. Amen.



TODAY

Rest both hands palm-up on your lap for one full minute. Don't pray. Don't fix anything. Only notice how they feel when they're open.

☐ DONE

What am I holding so tightly that my hands ache?

PSALM

36 — how precious is his loving kindness; the psalm for a hand that has stopped clutching.



DAY 307

What Control Cost You



Better is a handful, with quietness, than two handfuls with labor and chasing after wind.

ECCLESIASTES 4:6 (WEB)

Let's be honest this morning. Control felt like love. You checked the stove, the locks, and every phone number, because someone had to. And you were right. Someone did.

But look at the cost. The sleep. The tight shoulders. The way a grown child hears worry when you mean love. Walt, our old usher, counted the pews after Mass for thirty years. At eighty he let the young ones do it. He told me, "Father, I finally heard the sermon."

Today we only count the cost. Nobody is asking you to stop. Not yet.

Our Lady, I have kept watch over so many things that were never mine to guard. I did it out of love, and I did it out of fear, and I can't always tell which. Show me, gently, what it has cost me and the people near me. I'm not ready to let go of everything. Help me see one thing clearly today. Amen.



TODAY

Write one sentence that begins, "Keeping control has cost me..." Finish it honestly. Fold the paper once and leave it on the kitchen table.

☐ DONE

Who in my life feels my worry more than my love?

PSALM

47 — he is King over all the earth; you can put the steering wheel down.



DAY 308

Not My Will

saying, "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done."

LUKE 22:42 (WEB)

Today we say the hardest sentence in the prayer book. It isn't hard to say. It's hard to mean.

Jesus said it on the worst night of his life. He didn't pretend he wasn't afraid. He asked for another way first, and he said so plainly. Then he said, "Not my will, but yours." Notice the order. Honest asking, and then the open hand.

You're allowed to ask for what you want. Ask out loud. Then, when you can, add the second half. Even if it comes out small. Even if it shakes.

Father, you know what I want. I've told you a hundred times, and I'll tell you once more: I want it fixed. Now hear the rest. If your way is different from mine, give me the courage to want yours. Not today, perhaps. But start the turning in me. Mary, say it with me when my own voice fails. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, in your kitchen voice, one thing you're asking God for. Then add, "Not my will, but yours." Say the second half even if it comes out small.

☐ DONE

What am I asking God for that I'm afraid he'll refuse?

PSALM

48 — he will be our guide, even to the end; the psalm for handing over the steering.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that tied your knot is still out there. A heart opened this morning can close by supper. Come back to this page tomorrow. The tide doesn't take a day off.



DAY 309

Yes, Like Mary

Mary said, "Behold, the servant of the Lord; let it be done to me according to your word." Then the angel departed from her.

LUKE 1:38 (WEB)

Mary was young, and she was afraid. The angel's news changed everything in one sentence, and nobody had asked her first. She asked one question: how? Then she said yes. She said it with her whole life ahead of her and no map.

Her yes didn't mean she understood. It meant she stayed. It meant, "I'm here, and I'm yours."

You have your own small yes today. It may be about a doctor, a move, a child, or an hour you keep avoiding. You don't have to understand it. You only have to stay.

Mary, you said yes without a map. I have maps, and lists, and a dozen reasons to say not yet. Teach me your yes, the quiet kind, with the fear still in it. Stand beside me at the thing I keep putting off. When I can't find the words, say them in my ear. Let it be done to me according to his word. Amen.



TODAY

Name one small thing you've been putting off. Say out loud, "Let it be done to me." Then do the first two minutes of it.

☐ DONE

What would my small yes look like before lunch?

PSALM

50 — offer thanks, and call on him in the day of trouble; he answers the one who stays.



DAY 310

The Plan You Cannot See



For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways, and my thoughts than your thoughts.

ISAIAH 55:9 (WEB)

You like to see the whole road. So do I. We want the map before we start the car. But the people in the Bible were rarely given one. Abraham got a direction. Mary got an angel and a promise. Joseph got a dream.

Your life has a plan, and you can't see it from where you sit. That isn't the same as having none. A child in the back seat doesn't know the way home, and she isn't worried. She knows who's driving. His thoughts are higher than ours. That doesn't make them colder. It makes them reach farther.

Today, you only sit in the part you can see.

Lord, I can't see the road past the next corner. I've tried to peek, and it only frightens me. So I'll sit here, in my own chair, in the part of the day I can see. Light the next step. Keep the rest hidden until I can carry it. I trust that you can see all of it, and I trust that you love me. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your favorite chair for five minutes with your hands in your lap. When a plan tries to come in, say, "That's yours, Lord," and let it pass.

☐ DONE

What part of the road am I trying to see too far ahead?

PSALM

66 — you brought us through fire and water to a place of abundance.



DAY 311

Fear of Tomorrow



Don’t boast about tomorrow; for you don’t know what a day may bring.

PROVERBS 27:1 (WEB)

Tomorrow is the busiest place in your head. It has appointments, bills, empty chairs, and weather. It's also the one place you can't visit, which is why it grows so large.

The proverb never said tomorrow wouldn't matter. It said you can't know what a day may bring, so don't carry all of it today. Eileen, our widow in Scranton, used to write a long list every night for the day ahead. Then she tried writing only the first three lines. She said the list stopped looking like a wall.

Today we won't solve tomorrow. We'll leave it outside until you've had your breakfast.

Mother Mary, tomorrow is crowding into my morning again. It brings its worries with it, uninvited. I give you tomorrow. All of it, the appointments and the maybes. Keep it for me. I'll take only today's bread, today's walk, today's phone call. Stay with me in this hour, the only one I've truly been given. Amen.



TODAY

Pick one worry about tomorrow. Say, "I won't think about you until nine tomorrow morning." Write it on a scrap of paper and leave it by the door.

☐ DONE

What have I already decided about tomorrow that nobody has told me?

PSALM

64 — hear my voice in my complaint; preserve my life from fear.



DAY 312

Trust the Next Hour



LORD, be gracious to us. We have waited for you. Be our strength every morning, our salvation also in the time of trouble.

ISAIAH 33:2 (WEB)

You don't have to trust God with your whole life today. That's too big, and it would only tire you out. Trust him with the next hour.

That's how the shepherds did it, and the fishermen, and every grandmother who ever got through a hard week. One hour. You wash the cup. You answer the door. You sit down. When the hour is done, you lean on him for the next, the way you'd lean on a railing, one step at a time.

An hour is small enough to hold. Mary once held a whole Child. She can help you hold an hour.

Lord, I don't ask for the whole year, or the whole week. I ask for this hour. Let me do what is in front of me without looking over its shoulder. When the next hour comes, meet me there again. My soul is waiting for you in silence. It's a tired soul, but it is yours. Amen.



TODAY

Put your phone in another room. Look out a window for one full minute. Let the hour you're in be the only one you think about.

☐ DONE

What is the one thing in front of me this hour?

PSALM

62 — for God alone my soul waits in silence; changed from 76, which fit the day less.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 313 TO 319

This week: Aging as a Calling; Let Others Carry Something; Give Away What You Hoard; Into Your Hands.



DAY 313

Aging as a Calling



Yes, even when I am old and gray-haired, God, don't forsake me, until I have declared your strength to the next generation, your might to everyone who is to come.

PSALM 71:18 (WEB)

Nobody warned you that growing old is a job. It has duties, and they're not small. To be the one who remembers. To be the one who prays when the young ones are busy. To be the one who stays calm in the room.

Yes, the knees complain. Yes, the names slip away. But look at what stays: the stories, the patience, the long view no young person can buy. God doesn't retire his people. He moves them to the chair everyone turns toward when things go wrong.

Today we thank the body that brought you here.

God, my body is older than my heart feels. I thank you for the years it carried me, and I ask you not to forsake me now. Use what I have left. Let my prayers be my work, and my patience my gift. Mary, when I feel useless, remind me that someone in this family is held up by my prayers. Amen.



TODAY

Thank your body out loud, one part at a time: your knees, your hands, your eyes. Say it plainly, the way you'd thank a faithful old friend.

☐ DONE

What can only someone my age give to this family?

PSALM

71 — do not forsake me when I am old; changed from 41, which is for the sickbed.



DAY 314

Let Others Carry Something

But Moses' hands were heavy; so they took a stone, and put it under him, and he sat on it. Aaron and Hur held up his hands, the one on the one side, and the other on the other side. His hands were steady until sunset.

EXODUS 17:12 (WEB)

Some of us would rather carry the groceries up three flights than ask for help. Pride, yes, but mostly love. We've been the strong one for so long that we've forgotten how to be the loved one.

Tom, my neighbor, lives alone and is no longer young. For a year he refused every offer. One morning he let the girl from next door carry his bags. She stayed to talk. Later she told me she'd been lonelier than he was.

When you refuse help, you refuse someone the chance to give. Today, let somebody be generous with you. It costs you very little.

Father, I've carried more than my share, and I've called it strength. Teach me to ask. Give me the humility to say, "Could you help me with this?" and to mean it. Bless the person I ask, and bless the time we spend together. Let me be loved the way I've loved others, without keeping score. Mary, hold my pride while I do it. Amen.



TODAY

Call one person and ask for help with one small thing, like a ride, a lightbulb, or a recipe. Thank them warmly when they say yes.

☐ DONE

Whose kindness have I been refusing, and why?

PSALM

87 — all my springs are in you; you belong to a family that carries each other.



DAY 315

Give Away What You Hoard

There is one who scatters, and increases yet more. There is one who withholds more than is appropriate, but gains poverty.

PROVERBS 11:24 (WEB)

I'm not asking about your savings. I'm asking about the hall closet. The coats nobody wears. The second set of dishes. The jar of buttons from a house you left years ago.

We hoard because we've been afraid. Afraid of the day we'd need it. That's an honest fear, and God knows it. But a clenched house is a heavy house. I won't promise that giving makes your money grow. I only know that hands that give rest easier than hands that guard.

Pick one thing, only one, and let it go. The closet will forgive you.

Lord, you gave me all of it to begin with. The house, the dishes, the years. I'm afraid of having too little, and still I hold more than I use. Show me what to open my hands around today. Let it find the person who needs it. And when the shelf is lighter, let my heart be lighter too. I trust you with what's left. Amen.



TODAY

Choose one thing you haven't used in a year: a coat, a dish, a book. Put it in a bag by the door for someone who needs it.

☐ DONE

What am I keeping for a day that may never come?

PSALM

112 — he has given to the poor, and he will not be afraid of bad news.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

What you skip one day, you skip two. Then the closet fills again, and so does the heart. Come back to this page tomorrow. Giving is a habit, and habits have to be kept.



DAY 316

Into Your Hands

My times are in your hand. Deliver me from the hand of my enemies, and from those who persecute me.

PSALM 31:15 (WEB)

Every night of your life you have done something remarkable. You've put your whole self down on a mattress and trusted that you'd wake. Nobody taught you to do it. You just do.

"Into your hands" is that same act, said out loud and on purpose. Jesus said it from the Cross, and he had learned it from the psalms. It's one of the oldest prayers in the house. You give the day, the body, the family, and the keys, and you take your hands back empty and light.

Say it over small things first. Small things are how we practice.

Into your hands, Lord, I place this day. I place my keys, my glasses, my phone, the people I love, and the things I'm afraid to lose. I've held them as long as I can. Hold them better than I do. And when I forget I've handed them over, remind me gently, the way a mother reminds a child. Amen.



TODAY

Pick up your keys, your glasses, and your phone, one at a time. Hold each one and say, "Into your hands." Then set it down.

☐ DONE

What small thing could I hand to God before I leave this house?

PSALM

92 — still bearing fruit in old age; safe in the hands of the one who planted you.



DAY 317

The Last Word Isn't Yours

Above the voices of many waters, the mighty breakers of the sea, the LORD on high is mighty.

PSALM 93:4 (WEB)

You have been rehearsing an argument for years. Maybe with a sister, a doctor, a landlord, or a ghost. You know every line. You know exactly how it ends: with you being right.

But above the voices of many waters, the Lord on high is mightier. Somebody else holds the last word in your life, and it isn't the person who hurt you, or the one who's wrong. It isn't you, either. That's a mercy. Imagine being responsible for the final say.

Put the speech down. It's heavy, and the other person isn't listening anyway.

Holy Mother, I've said it in my head a thousand times. The speech is perfect, and it has never helped. I give you the last word. Let you and your Son settle what I cannot. I'll keep the little that is mine: to be kind, to be quiet, to be done. Loosen my jaw and my shoulders. Take the argument off my shelf. Amen.



TODAY

Drop your shoulders. Loosen your jaw. Open your hands. Notice which one was tightest, and breathe slowly until that one lets go.

☐ DONE

Whose argument am I still winning in my head?

PSALM

93 — above the roar of many waters, the Lord on high is mighty.



DAY 318

Be Still and Know



The LORD will fight for you, and you shall be still.

EXODUS 14:14 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Today the page is short, because the work isn't on the page. It's in the stillness.

"Be still" doesn't mean "feel nothing." It means let your hands drop. Stop straining at the oars. You were never the one holding this boat up. Lay the oars across your knees and let the water do what water does.

Two minutes. That's all this asks. You can do two minutes with a cup in front of you and a heart that's too full. If it spills a little, let it. The kitchen can take it.

Lord, it's quiet in this room, and the quiet is not empty. You're in it. I don't need to fill it with words today. Let my breathing be my prayer. Let my hands stay open on the table. If a worry comes in, I'll let it sit down and wait. You are God, and I am here. That is enough for this morning. Amen.



TODAY

Sit with your coffee and say nothing for two full minutes. Let the cup warm your hands. When a thought comes, let it pass like a car on the road.

☐ DONE

What is God saying in the quiet that I keep talking over?

PSALM

46 — God is a very present help; the quiet psalm for an anxious morning.



DAY 319

Thankful for the Ordinary

And let the peace of God rule in your hearts, to which also you were called in one body, and be thankful.

COLOSSIANS 3:15 (WEB)

Nobody gives thanks for the ordinary. It doesn't announce itself. The kettle that boils, the bed that's made, the neighbor who waves. These are the beams that hold up the house, and we've never looked at them.

Mrs. Doyle has cleaned our church for twenty years. Each morning she says "thank you" to the mop before she picks it up. I asked her why. She said, "It never complains, Father, and it has never once let me down."

Today we look at the beams. Walk through the house in your mind, and stop at the plain things. They've been faithful for years, and they never once asked for thanks.

Thank you, Lord, for the plain things. For the first cup, the warm water, the lock that still turns. For the soft chair, the voice on the phone, the bread in the house. I haven't thanked you enough for the things that never failed me. Teach me to see them while they're still here. Mary, thank him with me. Amen.



TODAY

Write down three ordinary things in your house that worked for you today. Don't pick special ones. Pick a spoon, a lamp, a door.

☐ DONE

What ordinary thing would I miss most if it vanished?

PSALM

95 — come before him with thanksgiving; the doorway into an ordinary day.



WEEK 3

Week 3

DAYS 320 TO 326

This week: Praise at the Window; A Morning Hymn; Fear of Dying, Gently; Put Your House in Order.



DAY 320

Praise at the Window

Sing to the LORD a new song! Sing to the LORD, all the earth. Sing to the LORD! Bless his name! Proclaim his salvation from day to day!

PSALM 96:1-2 (WEB)

Praise isn't for good days only. Praise is a way of looking. You can do it from a window, in your slippers, with the day not yet started.

Look at what's there. A bird with no savings account. A tree that grows in the dark of the ground. A sky that changes without asking you for help. None of it is yours, and all of it is given. The psalmist didn't sing because everything was fixed. He sang because he looked up.

Sing a little, or say it plain. God isn't grading the tune.

Praise to you, Lord, for the light coming through the glass. For the sound of the street waking up, and the day I didn't earn. I have problems, and you know every one. But right now I'm looking at something you made, and I'm glad of it. Take my small praise, though it comes in slippers. Mary, sing it with me. Amen.



TODAY

Stand at a window. Say out loud one sentence of praise for what you see, however small. Then say it once more, slower.

☐ DONE

What did I see this morning that I didn't make?

PSALM

96 — sing to the Lord a new song; proclaim his goodness from one day to the next.



DAY 321

A Morning Hymn

Light is sown for the righteous, and gladness for the upright in heart. Be glad in the LORD, you righteous people! Give thanks to his holy Name.

PSALM 97:11-12 (WEB)

Hymns used to be how our people got through the day. Women sang over the washing. Men sang on the way to work. Nobody asked if they sang well.

Do you have a hymn? One line from long ago that your mother hummed? It's still in you. The mind loses names but keeps tunes. That line is a rope you can pull on when the morning is heavy.

Light is sown for the righteous, the psalm says, like seed. Sown means scattered, small, and underground. You don't see it, and then one morning you do.

Hum it today. Badly is fine.

Lord, give me one line of song this morning. Let it come up from wherever it has been waiting. Let it rise through my kitchen and settle on my shoulders like a shawl. I don't have to sing it well. I only have to sing. Sow your light in me today, small and quiet, and let me notice when it comes up. Amen.



TODAY

Stand up. Lift your arms, then lower them slowly. As you do, hum or say one line of a hymn you remember.

☐ DONE

What song did I know by heart before I knew my troubles?

PSALM

97 — light is sown for the upright; a psalm for a heavy morning.



DAY 322

Fear of Dying, Gently

Nevertheless, I am continually with you. You have held my right hand. You will guide me with your counsel, and afterward receive me to glory.

PSALM 73:23-24 (WEB)

Let's say it plainly. You're afraid to die. Or you're afraid of how. Or you're afraid of being the one who is left. That isn't weak faith. Jesus wept at a grave and prayed in a garden until he was shaking.

Marguerite sings in our choir. The night her husband asked, "Will it hurt?", she didn't say no, and she didn't say yes. She said, "I'll be right here, and so will she." He slept.

I can't promise you the how. I can promise you the who. You will be held at the end by the same hands that held you at the beginning.

Mother Mary, you stood at the foot of a Cross, so you know the hour I'm afraid of. Be near it when it comes. Be near the people I'll leave behind. Until then, teach me to live without clutching the days. When I say, "Pray for us now and at the hour of our death," let me say it like a child who is not afraid of the dark. Amen.



TODAY

Breathe out the word "Mary" ten times, slowly, with one hand on your chest. Between each one, rest. Let the quiet be the answer.

☐ DONE

Who do I want to say one last good thing to?

PSALM

68 — a father to the fatherless; God sets the lonely in families.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I put this page down once, thinking I'd come back to it. I did, but the fear had grown while I was gone. Read it again tomorrow. Fear shrinks when you visit it often, and gently.



DAY 323

Put Your House in Order

Every wise woman builds her house, but the foolish one tears it down with her own hands.

PROVERBS 14:1 (WEB)

This isn't a gloomy page. It's a kind one. A house in order is a gift you leave in your own handwriting.

Think of the people who'll one day look for your papers. The insurance card, the list of who to call, the name of your parish. Wherever you've put them, you've put them well. Too well. A daughter shouldn't have to turn the house upside down while she is crying.

A wise woman builds her house, the proverb says, and then she looks after it. Today, looking after it means one folder and one sentence to someone you trust. Then you can breathe.

Lord, let me do this lightly. Let me gather my papers without gathering my fears. Make it a work of love for the people who'll come after me. Show me where things are and who should know. When the folder is closed, close the worry with it. Unless you build the house, we labor in vain. Build it with me. Amen.



TODAY

Put the papers your family would look for first into one folder. Tell one person where the folder is. That's all for today.

☐ DONE

What would make my family's hardest day a little easier?

PSALM

127 — unless the Lord builds the house; changed from 98, which fit the day less.



DAY 324

Say What Needs Saying

Let no corrupt speech proceed out of your mouth, but only what is good for building others up as the need may be, that it may give grace to those who hear.

EPHESIANS 4:29 (WEB)

There's a sentence you've been carrying for years. "I'm sorry." Or "Thank you." Or "I was proud of you and never said so." Maybe "I miss how we used to talk."

You've said it in the car, in the shower, to the ceiling. You haven't said it to the face, or into the phone. I understand. I forgot to call my sister for a year, and the longer I waited, the heavier the phone got.

A good word gives grace to the one who hears it. It doesn't cost much, and it lasts. Don't aim for a speech. Aim for the one true sentence.

Mary, you know the words stuck in my throat. Give me the courage to let them out. Go ahead of me to the person who needs to hear them. Soften their ear, and steady my voice. If they don't answer, let me still be glad I spoke. Let a few plain words do what long arguments never could. Amen.



TODAY

Call, or leave a voicemail, with the one sentence you've been saving. Keep it short, kind, and true. Then put the phone down and breathe.

☐ DONE

Who is waiting, without knowing it, to hear from me?

PSALM

99 — they called on the Lord, and he answered them.



DAY 325

What You Will Leave

A righteous man walks in integrity. Blessed are his children after him.

PROVERBS 20:7 (WEB)

You'll leave more than a house. You'll leave the way you said, "Sit down, you must be hungry." You'll leave the smell of your kitchen in someone's memory. You'll leave a tune you hummed without knowing.

The proverb says the children of an honest person are blessed after them. Nobody gives that person a medal. They simply lived honestly in front of a child.

Eileen began tucking small notes into a button tin, one line each. "Don't go to bed angry." "Salt the water." Her niece found them later, one by one. That is what a legacy is: small, and findable.

Lord, I won't leave much that can be counted. Let me leave what can't. Let a little of my faith stay in the people who loved me, like warmth in a chair. Give me the words to write, and the time to write them. Let what I leave be kind, and easy to find. Mary, bless the hands that will open it. Amen.



TODAY

Write a two-line note to someone you love about what you hope they'll keep. Put it in an envelope and write their name on the front.

☐ DONE

What do I hope they remember about the way I loved?

PSALM

100 — his faithfulness continues to all generations.



DAY 326

Glad of Today

This is the day that the LORD has made. We will rejoice and be glad in it!

PSALM 118:24 (WEB)

You don't have to love the whole day. You only have to find one thing to be glad about before it ends. That's a smaller job than you think.

Gladness isn't a feeling that arrives on its own. Sometimes it's a choice you make with both hands around a warm cup. "This is the day the LORD has made." It doesn't say an easy day. It says a made one.

You are still here to see it. I have buried friends who would have given anything to stand in your slippers and complain about the traffic.

Lord, I'm tired, and I'm still here, and I'm glad of this day. Let me say it again so I can believe it. Thank you for the plain light and the breath that goes in and out without my help. Whatever comes today, let me meet it as a day you made. Mary, remind me when I forget to be glad. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, "I'm tired, and I'm still here, and I'm glad of today." Say it to the room, then once more to your cup.

☐ DONE

What is one thing I'd be sorry to miss today?

PSALM

104 — I will sing to the Lord as long as I live.



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 327 TO 336

This week: Let the Rosary Hold You; Joy in Small Things; Praise Without Reason; The Gift of Weakness.



DAY 327

Let the Rosary Hold You

Seek the LORD and his strength. Seek his face forever more. Remember his marvelous works that he has done: his wonders, and the judgments of his mouth,

PSALM 105:4-5 (WEB)

A rosary isn't a test. It's a rope with knots you can hold when your mind won't. That's why it has lived in pockets and under pillows for so long.

You don't need to say the whole thing. Some mornings you'll get through one decade, and some mornings only the first bead. The beads don't mind. They sit in your hand and keep the rhythm for you, like a heartbeat you can carry.

Seek his face, the psalm says, and remember. Let the beads do the remembering. You only have to hold them.

Holy Mother, I come with few words and tired hands. Let these small beads carry what I can't. I'm too tired to talk much, and I know you understand. Take my fingers and my breath and my quiet. Pray the rest for me, as you always have. If I fall asleep halfway through, finish it for me. Amen.



TODAY

Take your rosary, or any string of beads, or a smooth stone. Hold it in your open hand for one minute. Let the weight settle. Say nothing.

☐ DONE

What does my hand reach for when I'm afraid?

PSALM

105 — seek his face always, and remember what he has done.



DAY 328

Joy in Small Things

He will drink of the brook on the way; therefore he will lift up his head.

PSALM 110:7 (WEB)

Joy is rarely big. It's the way the sun lands on the floor. It's bread still warm from the shop. It's a stranger holding a door.

Tom, my neighbor, told me his secret. "I walk to the mailbox slowly," he said. "There's usually nothing in it. I go for the air." He nods at the same maple every day, and he says it nods back. He lives alone, and he is not unhappy.

The psalm says the king drinks from the brook on the way. Not at the end of the road. On the way.

Lord, make me notice. Make me slow enough to see the small gifts you scatter on the path. The warm bread, the good light, the kind word from someone who didn't have to give it. I've walked past so many. Today let me stop and drink from the brook on the way. I'll thank you for each one. Amen.



TODAY

Walk to the mailbox slowly. Take one deep breath of outside air and look up once. Nod at whatever is nearest: a tree, a neighbor, a bird.

☐ DONE

What small thing made me smile before I could stop myself?

PSALM

110 — he will drink from the brook on the way; joy is found along the road.



DAY 329

Praise Without Reason



I will exalt you, my God, the King. I will praise your name forever and ever. Every day I will praise you. I will extol your name forever and ever.

PSALM 145:1-2 (WEB)

Today we praise God for no reason. Not because the bills are paid or the phone rang. Only because he is God, and you are here, and the morning is on your table.

That's the hardest kind of praise, and the cleanest. It doesn't bargain. It doesn't say, "Thank you, and now please." It simply says, "You are good." I learned it late. I used to thank him only after things went right, which is like thanking the weather for a good picnic.

Try it for one minute. You may feel foolish. Feel foolish, and praise anyway.

Lord, I have no list today. I'm not asking for anything. I only want to say that you are good, and I know it even on the days I can't feel it. You were good before I was born, and you'll be good long after this cup is empty. Blessed be your name, in this kitchen, in this plain hour. Mary, I praise him with you. Amen.



TODAY

Say "thank you" out loud to three things in the room, for no reason at all. Then say, "Lord, you are good," once, slowly.

☐ DONE

When did I last thank God without wanting something?

PSALM

111 — his works are great; praise him with your whole heart.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Mary doesn't tire of you, but you can forget she is there. A morning you skip is a morning you walk alone. Come back to her today. She has kept your place.



DAY 330

The Gift of Weakness

But we have this treasure in clay vessels, that the exceeding greatness of the power may be of God and not from ourselves.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:7 (WEB)

We were taught that weakness is a fault. Fix it, hide it, be ashamed of it. But look at what the Lord does with clay jars. He puts treasure inside them. The crack is where the light gets out.

Your tiredness is not a verdict. It's a door. When you can no longer do everything, you finally let someone help. And someone finally gets to love you in a way that's useful.

Mary was a small woman in a small town, and she carried God. Nobody called that weakness. It was the doorway.

Lord, I don't have the strength I once did. Some mornings I can barely lift the kettle. I'm ashamed of it, and I'm tired of being ashamed. Make my weakness a doorway for your strength. Let me lean without apology. Let those who help me know they are helping you. Be strong in the places where I'm cracked. Amen.



TODAY

Sit down the next time you feel tired, and don't apologize to anyone. Tell yourself, "This is how I'm praying right now."

☐ DONE

Who could love me better if I let them help?

PSALM

114 — he turned the rock into a pool, the flint into a spring.



DAY 331

Surrender Is Not Defeat



Not to us, LORD, not to us, but to your name give glory, for your loving kindness, and for your truth's sake.

PSALM 115:1 (WEB)

Surrender has a bad name. It sounds like losing, like a white flag. But there are two ways to open your hands. One is because you were beaten. The other is because you were held.

Dale drove for fifty years. When he finally gave up the keys, Patricia thought he'd lost something. A month later she told me, "He sits and watches the road go by. He says he finally sees it." It wasn't a defeat. It was a trade.

"Not to us, LORD, but to your name give glory." That's surrender with a smile on it.

Father, I've fought so long that I forgot there was another way. I'm not giving up. I'm giving over. There's a difference, and you know it. Take the wheel I've been gripping. Take the credit and the blame. Whatever I place in your hands won't be lost. Mary, show me how to open them without feeling small. Amen.



TODAY

Close your fists tight and hold for three seconds. Open them slowly. Do this three times, and on the last one say, "Held, not beaten."

☐ DONE

What would it feel like to be held instead of beaten?

PSALM

115 — not to us, Lord, but to your name give glory.



DAY 332

You Are Not Finished

being confident of this very thing, that he who began a good work in you will complete it until the day of Jesus Christ.

PHILIPPIANS 1:6 (WEB)

You are not finished. I know the knees say otherwise. I know the mirror says otherwise. But I once watched an old man plant a bush he would never see grown, and he planted it with a smile like a boy's.

God began a good work in you, and he doesn't leave things half-done. He isn't rushing, and he isn't bored. There's something left that only you can do. It might be a prayer, a phone call, a pot of soup, a hand on someone's shoulder.

Plant something today. You may never see the whole bush. That's all right.

Lord, you started something in me, and I believe you will finish it. Show me what is still mine to do. Let me plant what I'll never see grown, and not mind. Make my last chapters useful and my small days count. I don't ask to be young. I ask to be of use. Mary, keep me willing. Amen.



TODAY

Write one sentence that begins, "I'm not finished, because..." Put it where you'll see it tomorrow, on the fridge or the bathroom mirror.

☐ DONE

What is one small thing I'm still here to do?

PSALM

117 — the shortest psalm; his faithfulness endures forever, and so does his work in you.



DAY 333

The Company of Saints

As for the saints who are on the earth, they are the excellent ones in whom is all my delight.

PSALM 16:3 (WEB)

You have never prayed alone. Not once. Even in your emptiest kitchen at your quietest hour, there's a crowd around you. They are the ones who went before: the ones you knew by name, and the ones you know only by their pictures on the wall.

The Church calls them saints. I call them neighbors who got there first. Joseph, who worked with his hands. Monica, who prayed for a son for years. Jude, who gets the calls nobody else wants. They're not far. They're on your side.

Ask one to pray for you today. They love being asked.

Holy ones of God, I'm not alone, and I'm glad of it. Pray for me when my own prayers run thin. Stand near the people I love. Stand near me when I can't tell my left from my right. Thank you, Joseph, for the quiet, and Monica, for the patience. Walk me home, one day, among you. Amen.



TODAY

Say the name of one saint out loud: Joseph, Monica, Jude, or anyone you love. Then say, "Pray for me today." Wait a moment and smile.

☐ DONE

Who from my family do I imagine praying for me now?

PSALM

118 — the Lord is on my side among those who help me.



DAY 334

Offer the Whole Day

Therefore I urge you, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your spiritual service.

ROMANS 12:1 (WEB)

Before you stand up from this chair, there's one more thing. You can offer the whole day, as it stands. The messy parts too. The phone calls, the dishes, the waiting, the surprise. Nothing is too small to be offered.

Father Jakob, long ago, in Augsburg, is said to have begun each morning with one sentence. "It was yours before I woke." Then he got on with the day. He didn't pray longer. He only stopped treating the day as his own.

A day that's been offered still has dishes in it. The difference is that you stop carrying it alone.

Lord, here is my day, before it gets going. The things I planned, the things I'm dreading, the things I can't foresee. I give you my words, my steps, my patience, and my mistakes. Use what you can. Forgive the rest. Our help is in your name, who made heaven and earth. Let me walk into this day already given. Amen.



TODAY

Bow your head for ten seconds. Say, "All of it, Lord. Take all of it." Then stand up and begin your day.

☐ DONE

What part of today am I still treating as only mine?

PSALM

124 — our help is in the name of the Lord, who made heaven and earth.



DAY 335

Bless Your Own Hands

So I will bless you while I live. I will lift up my hands in your name.

PSALM 63:4 (WEB)

Nobody has ever blessed your hands. Think about it. They've been scrubbed, kissed, scolded, and wrung. They've done most of the loving in your life, and no one has thanked them.

I bless a lot of heads and hands. But I think the best blessing may be the one you give yourself. Take your right thumb and make a small cross on the back of your left hand. Then do the other.

The psalm lifts up hands and blesses God while it lives. Not your fame, not your fortune. Your hands. Look at them. They have worked well.

Lord, bless these hands. Bless the left one that steadied, and the right one that signed. Bless the lines in them, which are a map of everyone I've held. Let them keep working as long as you want them to. And when they rest, let them rest open. Let me lift these hands in your name, and make their work a work of love. Amen.



TODAY

With your right thumb, trace a small Sign of the Cross on the back of your left hand. Then do the other. Say, "Bless the work of my hands."

☐ DONE

What did these hands do this year that I'm proud of?

PSALM

132 — a place for God in your home; a house where hands are blessed.



DAY 336

The Surrender Candle

He won't break a bruised reed. He won't quench a dimly burning wick. He will faithfully bring justice. He will not fail nor be discouraged, until he has set justice on the earth, and the islands wait for his law.

ISAIAH 42:3-4 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. You've come to the last page of Open Hands. You may not feel changed. Let me tell you what I see. A person who sat in a chair and held their palms up to God, thirty-one mornings in a row.

That's not nothing. That's the whole thing.

Today, light the candle. Say the names on your Names Page. Say them slowly, and with each one open your hands a little wider. Father Matthias once told me the flame doesn't ask for much. It asks only to be lit, and watched.

Lord, here is the flame, small and steady. Here are the names I carry, and the knots I've handed you. I won't pretend I've given you everything. I've given you today. Take it, and what comes after. Mary, keep the light in my kitchen. If I forget to be open, tap my shoulder. I'll open my hands again. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle and say aloud three names from your Names Page. After each one, open your hands a little wider. Blow it out with an "Amen."

☐ DONE

What am I carrying today that I could hold more loosely?

PSALM

135 — praise him, for the Lord is good; he does what pleases him, and that is enough.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

What you opened this month won't close by itself, but it can swing shut when you forget it. A knot can tie again. Come back to your open hands tomorrow, and the day after.

LOOKING BACK AT OPEN HANDS

Take a pen. Answer each one in a line. Check the box if it's true.

☐ What is one thing I held more loosely this month than I did at the start?

☐ Which morning did my hands feel lightest?

☐ Who carried something for me, and did I thank them?

☐ What am I still gripping, and what would it take to open that hand?

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS, AT THE CLOSE

My friend,

Thirty-one mornings ago, I asked you to look at your hands. Look at them once more.

They are the same hands. The knots may be the same, too, some of them. But I think you hold them differently now. A little looser. A little more like a cup than a fist.

Don't forget this. A knot you loosen can tie again, and the quickest way back is a clenched hand. So open them again tomorrow. And the day after. That's all the secret there is.

Mary has not stopped walking beside you. She is not tired. She is pleased with your hands.

Father Lucas





THE SEAL AND THE CANDLE



Seal of the Month: *The Year of Untied Knots · Book 11 · Open Hands.* Add the date in your own hand.

The Open Hands Candle: Light a candle. Say the names on your Names Page, slowly, opening your hands a little wider with each one. Blow it out, and say, "Amen."

Turn to Book 12 tomorrow.



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 11 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 12 · NO KNOT TIES AGAIN